scholarship and authoritative texts to take back home, but were also among the world's earliest legendary adventurers and travel writers.

Buddhism arrived in China in the first century CE with traders and missionaries from India and Central Asia along the Silk Road and later on sea routes. The Kushan Dynasty, patrons of Buddhism based in Gandhara, played a key role in its transmission. Buddhism at first gained a following among the elite in China. But far as it was from its Indian roots, Chinese Buddhism grew based less on original scriptures, and more on derivative texts and local innovations. Buddhists were often misunderstood and defamed in China. Poor translations confused followers, as did contrary ideas from different schools of Buddhism across Central, South and South East Asia.

Nascent Buddhist communities in China therefore yearned for authentic sources on which their institutions, teachings and practices could be based. Many Chinese Buddhists also longed to see the places the Buddha had once inhabited. This, and not trade, tourism or secular inquiry, became the primary motive behind the steady stream of Chinese visitors to India in the mid-first millennium CE. It helped that the Sui and Tang Dynasties in China, from around 500 CE, had begun to patronize Buddhism, which by then had gained a critical mass of followers. Yijing himself wrote biographies of fifty-six pilgrims—mostly Chinese, a few Koreans and one Central Asian, which included five he had personally met. All of them had gone to India, learnt Sanskrit, visited pilgrimage sites, studied the Buddhist religion and philosophy at monasteries like Nalanda, and returned with ideas and books to enrich Buddhism at home.[3] There were likely hundreds more in the third quarter of the first millennium.[4] Many Indian monks also went as missionaries and scholars to China but none of their observations of China have come down to us.[5]

When Buddhism in India went into terminal decline around 800 CE and died out soon after 1200 CE, nearly all of its texts were lost forever (India's humid weather didn't help). Buddhism, its monuments and even the Buddha himself, were as good as forgotten by Indians. This changed only after the travel writings of Faxian, Xuanzang and Yijing were discovered and translated by European Indologists in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. Their eyewitness accounts of geography, society, customs,